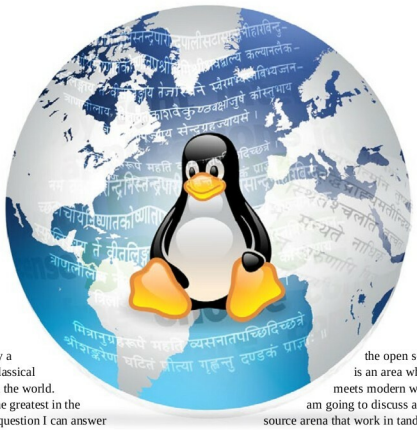
Sanskrit and the Open Source World

Way back in 1984, Dr Rick Briggs from the US recommended Sanskrit as 'the' language for interlingua machine translation. Since then, various initiatives have been taken to promote Sanskrit as a computer language. This article explores the potential of Sanskrit in relation to the open source milieu.



There are only a handful of classical languages in the world. Which of them is the greatest in the world? This is one question I can answer without any difficulty. It's Sanskrit, the language considered by many as created by the Gods themselves—a language that preserves the collective wisdom of our great sages since time immemorial. It is absolutely impossible to fully comprehend the hidden pearls of wisdom in many of the ancient Sanskrit texts. Consider the Sanskrit sloka '*gopi bhagya madhuvrata srngiso dadhi sandhiga khala jivita khatava gala hala rasandara*'. This sloka tells us about Lord Krishna, the eternal lover and his unmatched love for his *gopikas*. But hidden inside this sloka is the value of Pi up to 32 decimal places — a feat that was achieved by European mathematicians centuries later. A technique called *Katapayadi Sankhya*, where letters in the Sanskrit alphabet are given numeric values, is used to hide numbers of great importance in seemingly unrelated Sanskrit slokas.

The above example shows that Sanskrit texts are full of ancient wisdom. But what does Sanskrit have to do with the open source initiative? This is an area where ancient wisdom meets modern wisdom. In this article, I am going to discuss a few areas in the open source arena that work in tandem with Sanskrit. The topics I have covered in this article are not comprehensive. I am only discussing those open source projects that caught my eye during my research. But I do believe it is absolutely essential to have a comprehensive list of open source projects dealing with Sanskrit.

Online Sanskrit dictionaries

My search for Sanskrit related open source projects started with online Sanskrit dictionaries. When I Googled the phrase 'online Sanskrit dictionaries' I found many Sanskrit dictionaries with free content. But the result on the top, which was quite surprising, was *http://spokensanskrit.de/*. Google always returns results in the decreasing order of relevance. So this website is highly relevant according to Google. The domain extension *.de* is for Deutschland or Germany. So the best online Sanskrit dictionary is maintained by the Germans!

I have gone through the contents of the website — it not